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Sheila Jordan

Vocalist Sheila Jordan was born in Detroit on November 18, 1928. Her uncompromising style and ability to adapt the language of bebop to voice has made her a favorite among jazz fans and a welcome bandmate with fellow artists. Sheila currently is enjoying an active schedule of performing and promoting the music she loves both here and abroad.

Sheila was interviewed in Middleburgh, NY on May 11, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive outside Middleburgh, New York. I'm very pleased to have jazz musician Sheila Jordan with me today. Thank you for inviting us into your house.

SJ: My pleasure.

MR: Not exactly on the beaten path.

SJ: Well it's a little bit out — they don't call it "Hunter's Land" for nothing. I mean there's so many wild animals running around up here. But I like it.

MR: It's beautiful.

SJ; It's wonderful.

MR: How long have you been here.

SJ: I moved here, I bought this land about 1981. There was an old house that sits in front of this one, it was 150 years old, and I was out on tour in Canada and had just finished renovating it in 1991, ten years later, and it burned to the ground. And I was like in shock. But nobody was hurt. And all of my pictures were saved so that was an amazing kind of thing, that all the pictures, the things that really meant a lot, most all pictures of just everybody you know, and so that was a good thing, that I got the pictures. And then this house, I moved it back a little further from the road and I've been very happy here. It's a little bit more comfortable for me in the sense that it's not thirteen rooms. I don't know, my idea of when I even bought the place was, as you saw my lawn, it's called Charlie Parker Place. And I got that sign, a street sign from a festival that they did on his birthday, the first festival they did when they named a street in New York City after Bird. Charlie Parker Place. And I did the first concert, actually the first two concerts. And they gave me that street sign. And I said well I don't know if I'll ever get the money together to have a workshop up this way but we can dream, we've gotta dream. So I called it Charlie Parker Place.

MR: Great. When you look at your career as a musician, what's happening right now, do you feel it's a good place for you?

SJ: This is the best time in my life right now. I can't believe what's happened to me. I mean I'm going to be 74 in November, and what has happened to me every year has become more and more and more. Between going away and doing like workshops in other countries and concerts, being able to re-establish the bass and voice again, I was doing that for about 18 years with Harvey Swartz and then he felt he didn't want to do it anymore which was fine, you know, he's a wonderful musician. But I didn't want to let it go. Because I am the pioneer of the bass and voice. I go back to the early 50s, like '52 or '50, something like that. And I remember thinking, and everyone said oh what are you out of your mind?

MR: Was it a conscious thing at that time? I mean sometimes those things — I've heard stories about well this saxophone, this bass thing happened simply because the other people didn't show up.

SJ: Oh no mine was like, mine was I loved the bass. And I remember thinking — actually my Blue Note album, I wanted it to be bass and voice but it was a little bit — nobody wanted to take that chance yet. But thanks to George Russell, who got me the Blue Note date, had made it a trio with guitar, Barry Galbraith, the wonderful Barry Galbraith, and so it was pretty similar but not quite. And there were a couple of things I did with bass and Denzil Best on drums. But originally I wanted that to be a bass and voice. But I had been into the bass and voice and practicing it and doing it, because I loved the sound of the bass, and then Peggy Lee came out with that "Fever." And the same thing happened with a string quartet I wanted to do years ago. And Stan Getz came out with "Focus." So I said you know, then I'm not so crazy. And well Peggy Lee only did one tune, and I think she had drums too on "Fever," but I really had been doing it just with the bass. Actually my first bass partner, the first time I ever performed it was with Charles Mingus in Toledo. And he said, "Well why don't you come up and sing with us." And I'd been sort of doing it a lot, but Lennie Tristano is one I was studying with, Lennie, and different sessions, but never out anywhere. And I said, "Well there's no piano." And he said, "Well that shouldn't bother you." And I said, "Oh well that's true." And so I did a duo with Charles Mingus. And I'll never forget it. It was "Yesterdays." It was "Yesterdays" in G minor. And now I do "Yesterdays" in F minor, so my voice hasn't changed that much.

MR: Just a step.

SJ: Yeah, exactly one step, right. But I remember that. And then I grabbed Steve Swallow, because he used to work at this club in the Village where I worked a couple of nights a week and on Monday nights he'd come in and play, and I started doing the things with him and then every once in a while we'd do a little date together. There was a club in the Village that did a lot of sort of avante garde type music called the Take Three, and it was upstairs. And we would go up there, carry the bass up there and do this concert. It was

wonderful. Yeah. And I've been doing it ever since. It's just that now I've gotten back together with Cameron Brown. Because originally he had rehearsed bass and voice with me but then he got very busy with some of the other musicians you know. And he couldn't rehearse as much. And then Harvey of course came in to the picture from the Steve Kuhn Quartet.

MR: When you talk about rehearsing, how much does it affect the final performance?

SJ: It's like — you know what? It's like a map. Getting into it, knowing how to get into it, and knowing how to get out of it. And that's it. The rest is pretty open. I mean nothing's ever really set. There's a lot of freedom with the bass and voice, a lot. So I love that. I love that freedom to be able to even go into another song if necessary. And I always say, as I did to Harvey or as I do to Cameron now, "Don't try to follow me. If you don't know the tune or if you don't know where I'm going, just lay out. When in doubt, lay out." And I'm on top of it. I'll know when to bring it back in again. So the thing is having that freedom and having the other musician not be worried about whether or not — how are we going to get out of this, how did we get into it. So it's just like really learning the tune. Just like you would teach your students, as I teach my students, learn the way it was written. Exactly the way it was written. Learn the tune the way it was written. What is the true melody of this tune?

MR: Yeah, I remember reading a quote from you about go to the sheet music first.

SJ: That's right.

MR: And you also said don't learn songs by listening to singers.

SJ: That's right.

MR: Because?

SJ: You want to know why?

MR: Yes.

SJ: Okay. The reason being, there's many reasons for this as far as I'm concerned. Being a singer myself, I've made a lot of mistakes. I don't stick to the melody, I don't all the time, I don't deliberately try to change it, but organically something just happens musically and the spirit takes over and you can be off and running. Now if I were a young person learning from me, I'd never learn the song right. I wouldn't know how that song went. There's mistakes with lyrics, there's mistakes with timing, there's mistakes with melodies. You will sing what they sing, and you will think that's the original melody and it isn't. So you have no place to go except where that singer you heard, and you learned from, you will go where they went. And so I try not to do that. I find that — learn the way it was originally done.

MR: Yeah. It makes me think of Billie Holiday when she did "A Sunny Side of the Street," she basically took the whole first four bars and did it on one note.

SJ: Yes. Yes.

MR: You know, so if that was the first time you heard the song—

SJ: You'd think that's the way it went. And the amazing thing about Billie Holiday, she was such a — this is a new expression of mine, I have a couple of new expressions in singing — she was so organically creative, and it was so natural, that to hear her you would think that's the way that melody went. It almost seemed that she never tried to do something different, it just happened organically with her. She was like, you know? And I was amazed when I really started — after I had established my own sound and my own feeling, I always listen to singers now, don't get me wrong. I listen to singers to be inspired. I didn't learn from singers you know. I listen to be inspired and to enjoy, like any fan would. But when it came to actually studying I listened to the instrumentalists. Because I was a bebop freak man, I was a Charlie Parker freak. He was my musical guru. That was it. But and the other thing, my other expression I have several expressions I use now [oh that's my clock going, letting us know] the other thing that I'm into today, an expression that I've found somewhere in my head of feeling is that of scat singing. I think there's a scat virus going around, and we haven't found an antibiotic for it yet. And some of us have, but some of us haven't. And my other expression I've been using for years now, these kids that come, being a teacher as well you know, being a teacher, the first thing they want to do is scat. But most of the time they don't even know a tune, or that many tunes. And I say — or they'll come and say, "Well I'm not a jazz singer because I don't scat." And so I say well you know what? Would you say Billie Holiday wasn't a jazz singer? You know? And they say oh, that's right. And then they realize it and they say oh, and then it's okay. But I just think, I think scat singing is sort of like a whole different type of music in a sense, or a whole different — not a type of music — but a whole different approach to jazz music. You sing with lyrics and you sing with syllables. It doesn't mean that you can't improvise with lyrics. I improvise with lyrics constantly, re-phrasing and the whole scene. But to scat sing, I don't want to just get up there and do a few shoobie-doobies and let that be it and then all of a sudden I'm so hip I'm square.

MR: Where do you come up with more than shoobie-doobie?

SJ: Well I got it from Bird. I mean there was no way in the world that I could try to learn a Bird solo, which was teaching myself this, nobody ever said oh go learn Bird. I was so crazy about bebop music and Bird that I wanted to sing everybody's solo. Try to sing everybody's solo. So I learned all these bebop lines. And in so doing there was no room in there for shoobie-doobie. [scats] I mean it's pretty hard isn't it?

MR: Yeah. You couldn't get it out fast enough.

SJ: No, no. Not on "Confirmation," or any of those tunes. So if I'm going to sing "Confirmation," [scats] I mean I can't do it. So I just learned in order — and plus I

should also say that I had two wonderful young musicians that were wonderful singers in Detroit, Skeeter Speight and LeRoy Mitchell, we called him Mitch but his real name was LeRoy Mitchell. And those two guys took me under their wing when I was very young. They were young too but they were two young Afro-American musician singers, and I just wanted to do this music so bad. And the only thing was I was young and I drank a lot. And they'd say well we'll teach you this, but you've got to stop drinking. And I did for a while. And they taught me a lot. They had wonderful, wonderful syllables. So I would say, to answer your question again, is that it was really listening to the instrumentalists. When I first went to Lennie Tristano, Mingus took me to Tristano to study. And my first lesson was, "Do this Charlie Parker solo." And I said, "Well I know it." And he said, "Oh really?" And I said, "Yeah." And he said, "Well let's hear you sing it." So he put the record on and of course I sang Bird's solo and everybody else's solo. Not great, but you know what I mean. I knew it. And he said, "Oh, you do know it." And I said well you know, then I started feeling like smart ass. You know how you get into it. Well I guess I showed you.

MR: I don't need this teacher.

SJ: But I knew that I did, you know, but I had low self esteem so that really lifted my self esteem up a couple of notches. He said, "Well I'll tell you what," he said, "do you know Prez?" I said, "No." He said, "All right, so then why don't you learn a Prez solo?" And so he gave me "Tickle Toe."

MR: That's usually the way instructors do too. Instead of — he went backwards on you, right?

SJ: Uh huh. That's right. Yeah. And he waited and he let me go through my whole little ego trip, and then he was so cool. I went wow, I'll never forget that. I can still see that.

MR: Was there a kind of controversy at the time when Bird came out about — I've read about the moldy figs, the people that just didn't like what he was — In fact I had this quote from Harry "Sweets" Edison. He said he was talking about Charlie Parker and he said, "He made such an impression on the musicians that if he played a melody wrong, and if you told one of his disciples that the melody was wrong you might get knocked out."

SJ: We were pretty avid fans. I mean yeah, I can believe that. Yeah, I would argue that whatever Bird did was cool. He was, right, I didn't like him destroying himself. I got to know him quite well. I mean I wanted to be around Bird so much I married his piano player. How's that? Not really but, no, nobody could say anything about Bird. He was our God you know, a musical God.

MR: When I watch some films, I guess I'm thinking of the Ken Burns thing, a lot of times they make assumptions. I think they're assumptions, about the social implications of some of the jazz pioneers, as if his music was a social statement about freeing himself, freeing the

members of his race. Do you think that what he did had social implications or was it more just his musical prowess?

SJ: I never thought it had social implications. I just thought he was Bird and he was a genius. And I always felt like he was in transient here. It's the same I felt about Billie Holiday and even Fats Navarro and some of the great players that left us so early. But in Bird's case, I really always felt that he was like a bird. He flew here, he blew those notes, he showed us that music and then he took off again. I thought he was just here to show us the way. I never found it was social. I don't know, maybe it was, but knowing Bird and talking to Bird and spending quite a lot of time with Bird, especially in the latter years, he came by my loft a lot and he spent a lot of time at my loft. And he never got into that. He was just like, his whole thing was the music. He never said well I'm doing this music because this music was written for the poor blacks of the south. I never heard him say anything like that. I mean he might have felt it. Maybe just subconsciously that was in his music, which I'm sure that whole soul, that whole feeling, that whole, I mean it was amazing what Charlie Parker did. But to actually sit down and analyze it or anything, no that wasn't Bird. Everything he did was just sort of — just there, it just came out. It was like whoa. I mean I used to — he'd play one note — I can hear two notes today, or maybe even one, and I know it's Bird. And still I'll be riding in my car and I'll hear Bird, just talking about him, and the hair just stands up on my arm, because the sound and just this whole intensity and his whole sound, but again, maybe subconsciously it was.

MR: How did he feel about being – as you said — a God? Was he confident about his own abilities?

SJ: I think in the end, when he was drinking so much after he had put down the heroin and he got into really, really heavy drinking, people drink and drug because of low self esteem and an insecurity and a fear. And I can say this because I've been there, you know, and I have since like been getting myself together for the last twenty-some years. But unfortunately Bird did not find that way. I feel that he was — I don't know, I got the feeling from Bird that he knew that he had originated a new music, a new way to play, to hear, whatever you want to call it, whatever it is. He knew that he was a pioneer of this bebop, one of the pioneers of this bebop music. I think what happened with Bird towards the end was he was afraid that he was not able to go on and keep progressing. Sometimes we have to be settled into where we are. Okay, this is what I did, this is how I do it, I found my peak. That doesn't mean I can't spurt off in other little places, but am I going to go another step? Am I going to go like a pyramid? Am I going to keep building? And you can sometimes get stuck there. And I know that. Of course Bird to me was a genius. And again it's that transient thing with me, that he wasn't supposed to go any further. But I think that he, in the end, he was very sad. And I think, I got the feeling that there was a

part of him that he wanted to be like I'm the Bird you know, and there was another part of him that didn't want all that pressure of being this pioneer, and do I have to keep doing this? When can I relax and just enjoy life? And that never seemed to happen. This is my own personal feeling about Bird and the time that I spent with him and got to know him. And I could be dead wrong. But this is the feeling that I got from him is that I don't want to be up here, I want to play my music the way I play it, and I want to enjoy my life. And sometimes when you're insecure like that with having that feeling of I'd better keep — you have to take substitutes or whatever you want to call them, what do we call them, I can't remember anything anymore.

MR: Chemical help I guess.

SJ: Yes. Chemical help. Yes. Chemical substitutes to sort of like not bring ourselves down or kind of feel a little better or more secure, to get rid of the fear. It's a fear. That's what it is, it's the fear of like oh my God, how long before they catch up with me, and then where do I go. Do you know what I mean? Now, you know, when you've really settled into what you do and have your own thing, who cares? Please catch up with me. I hope you do.

MR: Is music at all spiritual to you?

SJ: Oh God it's the most spiritual thing in the world. I've had spiritual experiences, which I'm sure — and one time I read about Sonny Rollins having this, and I see him every once in a while, well I used to see him more because when I take the train from Hudson back to New York City, when I have to go back to Manhattan, because I still maintain an apartment there, I used to see Sonny and his wife. And he would like buy me breakfast on the train you know. And we'd talk about — and I said, "You know, man, I've got to tell you something. I read something that you said one time in an interview" and I said, "and I've written about this too, and it's the feeling of that spiritual experience where it's not you doing it. Like you leave your body kind of thing. And you're floating over. I know this sounds totally out. But maybe you've experienced it. But you don't get it that often. I think I can count on one hand, and leave a few fingers free, the times I've felt it. But when it hits, oh my God, it's unbelievable.

MR: And you probably can't make it happen.

SJ: No, no, no, no, no, no, no, no.

MR: Because if you could—

SJ: No, no, no. You'd want to do that all the time you know. It's too overwhelming. The feeling is so overwhelming that you're just floating. And you're watching yourself almost. It's like you leave your body and you're floating over this form which is you. And these sounds. I have had this happen, where I've sung sometimes — well always when I sing I get totally like into another world. I mean in that sense I'm not like this

fabulous kind of like entertainer where I'm, you know, I mean I sort of close my eyes and just get into the music. But I have had this happen where I've gone somewhere on a tune, I never think about improvising, oh I'll do this here, I'll do this here, I let it happen. That's that organic thing again, or spiritual thing. And I've had that happen where I've gone somewhere or sang a phrase or a note or something and it's like — that clock you know — that clock ticking. Sometimes I improvise with it. But it'll go like, the thing, the whole thing will happen and you'll say oh my God where did that come from? In other words your reverie is interrupted. Your reverie of this whole beautiful, musical experience is interrupted because you're shaken to — where'd that come from? You know? Which is a little different than the leaving your body thing. Now that happens a little bit more often. Like it's almost like you look around and say oh, who sang that? Did you ever have that happen?

MR: I don't think I have.

SJ: Oh well you're young yet. It'll happen. Give yourself time.

MR: Okay.

SJ: It's amazing. Have you ever left your body?

MR: No I never have.

SJ: Oh my God, well a lot of it has to do who you're playing with too.

MR: Sure. You've got to have the right situation.

SJ: No because when you all become one sound you know? It's something.

MR: Wow. Do the words of songs ever disappoint you in that they don't match up — or let me rephrase — I think you said one time that when you look for songs you look for the melody first.

SJ: Yes I do.

MR: The lyrics second. I'm just wondering if the words are sometimes almost an impediment to doing the song.

SJ: Okay I'll explain that a little better, of what I've said. I do listen first for the melody. Because when it's a beautiful melody immediately I'm drawn to the tune. That's what draws me is this beautiful melody. Now as far as the lyrics are concerned I'm very, very concerned with lyrics. And throughout the years I've been told that I had no regard for the lyrics by some critics, not all, but a few, and that's okay. If they want to think that good, it's what I know. That's their problem. I know I'm very much into the lyrics you know. The thing is is sometimes there's these beautiful, beautiful melodies and I'll pick this tune because I love this melody, but there'll be certain lyrics that just are stupid — well I shouldn't even stay stupid, maybe to some people they're not stupid, but to me they don't' mean anything. I can change that. I can change those lyrics, which I do. I'm famous for changing lyrics. You know? So if there's a lyric that — I love this song so

much and there's a lyric that I don't like, I'll change it around. I'll have the same idea of what — I respect the lyricist, and I'll stay to the same idea, it's just that maybe I'll just rephrase the whole thing lyrically so that it makes more sense to me. That's what I do. I do that a lot.

MR: Okay. Because sometimes when you look I mean there's some beautiful songs, I mean I think of "I Can't Get Started" for instance, things like that, and then it's saying "I've started revolutions in Spain" or maybe there's a phrase that's kind of like, oh I wish he hadn't written that.

SJ: Yeah, yeah.

MR: So you fix that, huh?

SJ: Yeah I fix it. If it bothers me I fix it. Again, what might bother me might not bother you and vice versa so if — there's a song called "I See Your Face Before Me." [sings] I see your face before me/Haunting my every dream/There is your face before me/You are my only — I forgot the lyrics. It doesn't matter where you are/I can see how fair you are. I always sang that song for my daughter. Now my daughter is brown skinned. So for me to sing fair — how fair you are — so I say I can feel how near you are.

MR: I see.

SJ: So I've changed it you see? And it's things like that which I'll do. But I've taken "I've Grown Accustomed to Your Face" and changed all the lyrics to [sings] "I've Grown Accustomed to the Bass/It almost makes my day begin/I've grown accustomed to the sound/I love it pound for pound/The highs, the lows, the strings, the bow.

MR: Oh that's marvelous.

SJ: And so on. I'll give you one of those CDs for your school.

MR: That's great. Terrific.

SJ: But you know, again, the melody is the most important thing in the beginning for me when I hear a tune, it's got to be a really lovely melody. My eyes are watering like crazy because I have such an allergy. Can I stop for a minute maybe? I don't know if that's going to show up, but does it really matter?

[pause]

MR: I saw some really nice plaques from the City of Detroit on your wall, nice. And it's curious a couple of them said that at the time the music you were into was called rebop.

SJ: Yeah, it started out being rebop.

MR: I guess I had read that but I never —

SJ: Charlie Parker and his Reboppers.

MR: That's right.

SJ: That was the first record I ever bought was Charlie Parker and his Reboppers. Can I remember the label? Jeez I used to know but I can't remember now. Yeah, Charlie Parker and his Reboppers. But shortly after that it went to bebop.

MR: Okay. Was there a Detroit sound? Do you think there is a Detroit sound?

SJ: Woooah, yeah. We're all originals. I mean most of them. Look at Tommy Flanagan. I grew up with Tommy and Barry and Kenny Burrell and we are all very close. And our hero at the time, from Detroit, was Hank Jones and Milt Jackson. Because Milt Jackson had gone off with Dizzy Gillespie and Hank Jones had been out there for a while, even though he wasn't originally from Detroit. So we had our own — we were struggling with this music, you know, going around. I should say I was struggling with it. Because the prejudice in Detroit was not to be believed.

MR: No kidding.

SJ: Oh it was horrible. They would stop us in the car, if they'd see you mixing they used to call it. Mix. They didn't want you to mix as they say, you know, the blacks with the whites. And they'd see you in a car, the cops would stop. "Where were you born? Where are you going? Where are you coming from?" I mean third degree like you wouldn't believe. I've been taken down to the police station in Detroit when I was going with Frank Foster. We were going out to Belle Isle, Frank Foster and myself were in the back and my girlfriend and the guy she was going with, they were sitting in the front. And we were both white and they were black you know, or Afro-American. These cops, plainclothesmen, stopped us and gave us the third degree. And then I threw a cigarette out of the car, and of course they crawled under the car to get that cigarette because they thought I was smoking dope. And in those days if you got caught with marijuana, I would still be in jail in Detroit. I mean they — anything that they could get on me as a young white girl hanging out with black musicians, they were going to be on your case. I never went out with people for that reason. I went with them because I didn't even know color. I'm one-quarter Cherokee Native American. So am I gonna? I mean I know that feeling growing up being called a half-breed and the whole trip, when I still lived in Pennsylvania with my grandparents as a kid. I knew that prejudice. So to walk into this prejudice was like so heavy. I mean I fought so hard to do this music, and that was one of the hardest battles, was to not have the fear to stick up to these people of authority knowing that I was right and they were wrong. And they were the problem, not me. But the last time I got busted, I call it, was Frank Foster in the car, they took us down, they separated the women from the guys. This cop said to me, and I'll never forget it as long as I live, he said, "I'm going to tell you something." He said, "I have a 9-year-old daughter," he said, "if I caught my daughter the way I caught you tonight, if I thought that was going to happen to her I would take this gun and go home and blow her brains

out." I swear to God, Monk, I swear to God. That is what he said to me. And I thought oh my God and then something said don't say nothing. Shut up. He's waiting to get your reaction and if you flip out they'll put you for assaulting an officer or whatever, you know? So I said, "Oh, gosh," I said, "boy that's strong," or something like that I said. Well I said, "I'm not going to be staying in Detroit anyway." I said, "I'm going to New York." Well I was chasing Bird you know. So he said, "Oh we're so cosmopolitan." You know? And I didn't say anything. All of a sudden some little voice that takes care of me said, "Shut up. Don't say anything. They're waiting." I came to New York and I was walking on my street, I was having these sessions in my loft like you wouldn't believe. Everybody showed up there. Sonny Rollins, everybody came to my loft. Monk, everybody. Naturally Bird was always there. There's a session going full bloom, a lot of the kids that were studying with Lennie Tristano and going like this, I think Warne Marsh was up there that night playing. I went out with two young black painters, artists, to get some food. On my way back four guys, white guys, jumped out of the bar on the corner where I lived and held the guys and threw me down and started beating me up, actually knocked one of my teeth out. And all of a sudden I looked up and I saw this guy in this tweed overcoat, and he had a gun drawn. And I said oh my God, here I left Detroit to come to New York to get away from this and now I'm going to get murdered. Here he's going to kill me. You know? For being with black friends, which I don't even think about. He was a plain clothesman. And he saved my life. [clock] These guys were kicking me like you wouldn't believe. He comes over and he says, "Do you know this woman? Is she related to you?" "No, officer." He of course showed his badge, because he was a plain clothesman. So then he took them aside and then he took me and he said, "What do you want to do about this? Do you want to press charges?" And I said, "Yeah." He said, "I'm going to tell you something. They know where you live, so you do what you want." He said, "I'll do anything you want me to do." So I talked to the two guys that I was with, the two painters, and they said, "Sheila, let it go." Sometimes I wonder, did I do the right thing?

MR: Yeah.

SJ: I don't know if I ever did the right thing you know. I thought oh they need to be punished.

MR: But there's self-preservation you have to consider.

SJ; There was. And they did know where I lived. And they actually weren't even from the neighborhood they just happened to be passing through. But how is that for a story? Isn't that bizarre?

MR: That's amazing. This was before you were married in New York?

SJ: Yeah. Before it was — well actually no. I wasn't married. I was married but we were kind of separated for a year or so. I don't know, we had lived in Brooklyn and then I moved to New York and when I started studying with Lennie Tristano and then Duke sort of, we sort of had this year of separation and then we got back together again and then of course my daughter, I had my daughter.

MR: Was that, did you ever have any similar incidents with your marriage like that?

SJ: Uhh. No, and I'll tell you why. Because once Duke and I got married, we weren't together very long. It was weird. We actually were together a total of seven years, but up until the time after my daughter was born, shortly after my daughter was born, I was just too much for him and he had his own personal problems which I won't go into detail, and he left. And you know, now that I think back about it, it was the best thing that ever happened to me. He did me the biggest favor in life. Because trying to deal with his emotions and what he was going through and it was very difficult, and then having this baby, which I raised by myself, so it was not easy. But I used to get a lot of prejudiced remarks about her. I remember one time I was taking — my daughter loved the beach. And we'd go out to Reese Park and there'd be like these young boys would come around and they'd form a circle and they'd say, "Yaaaah look at the little Nigger baby ahhh" and they'd point at her. And I often wondered, gee I wonder if she ever remembered that. I remember one time I was on the subway and there was this white woman with two kids and she sat there and I had my daughter. And she said, "Ohhh, look at the cute little colored baby, where did you get her?" It's amazing how your higher power works, comes right on the scene for you, comes into your brain. I never would have thought this, but somebody else did, somebody of much more magnitude. And I said, without even, it's one of those where did that come from — not in music, but in protecting myself or showing off or whatever — I said, "oh, you like her?" "Yeah she's so cute, where'd you get her?" I said, "Are those your two children?" And she said, "Yes." I said, "Well I got her the same way you got them." And I don't know where that came from, but it was out you know. And then sometimes I think jeez, where does these – it must be from the Native American side of me. I mean I don't know where it came from, but it just comes like, things like that happen. But harassment, not to the point where I was beat up anymore. Well comments once in a while, but again with Duke, I don't remember any incidents with Duke. But then again, we hung out at night, I'd go to the clubs where he was working or, I sort of like let it pass over. But I remember in Detroit at one point getting so tired of being stalked by the cops when I was living there that I just told them that I was mixed. And they figured well who would dare want to be part black? She must be telling the truth. But I said, this is what I said, I said, "What I can't be with my brothers?" Again that was another one of those. When I say like really working hard for

this music, I was. That's why today if it's like the reverse prejudice now, against white musicians among some of the younger musicians coming up, some of the younger Afro-American musicians coming up, I think oh my God if you only knew how much I suffered to keep this music alive. Whether it's singing it, spreading the word, going to the clubs, teaching it, whatever. You have no idea how hard I worked. If you know what I went through to preserve this music, it was the most important thing in my life. It came before practically anything. It was on the same level as my daughter. You would never, ever get an attitude about it's not my culture. That was said to me one time. "Oh she's a wonderful singer but it's not her culture."

MR: I notice one of the things on your wall here, it's a plaque from the Society of Culturally Concerned. And it says, "For lifetime achievement and major contribution to African-American music."

SJ: Yeah.

MR: Is jazz—

SJ: Well Detroit was never like that. The people in Detroit, the musicians in Detroit never thought about me as this little white chick trying to do the music. I was just —

MR: Doing the music.

SJ: Doing the music. And they knew that I had a unique way of doing what I did, whether it was great or not so great or whatever, who cared? You know I don't even think about that. But they always accepted me. And I got accepted by Bird. I mean I feel this way: if Charlie Parker could accept me, and you can't accept me, then I'm sorry, you must have a problem.

MR: I've already passed the audition.

SJ: Yeah really. You know, if Bird was working at a club somewhere or at a concert somewhere, you know like a little dance, they used to have these cocktail sips, and he could ask me to get up and sing with him. You know. He must have thought I had something going on, that I had a love for the music, not even something going, but a love for the music. So I just, you know, that worries me. What worries me today, and I hope it's resolved, is like this reverse kind of thing that happens once in a while with the younger black musicians coming up as far as prejudice against white musicians. I'm not saying that they don't sometimes, but nobody, I have never ever tried to steal any music from black musicians. I've always said where I got it from. I've gotten it from Bird and all those wonderful musicians and taken it and tried to adapt it into what I do, what I feel and what I teach. I've always given credit to the greats, which are Billie, which are Prez, which are Bird, which are Bud Powell, Monk, Ellington. You know, always.

MR: The state of jazz these days seems to have found its ways of course into universities and the academic world. Is that a good thing?

SJ: I knew you were going to ask me this. I'm going to be very honest. In some ways it is and in some ways — and this is only me and I'm not that important as far as my word but I speak but I feel — in some ways it is and in some ways it isn't. In the ways that it is is it makes people aware of this wonderful music, which is American, which hopefully will close the gap between black and white, I hope. I'd like to see that happen. You play, you play. I don't know, what color are you? I don't know, is there a color here? And never forgetting where the roots came from and where it started from, not forgetting that. That kind of thing is bringing people more aware of what's going on with the music and these kids are learning, and they're learning technical stuff that I never had the chance to learn the way I would have liked to. You know I think I could have been a composer, but not having the chops in composition I had to put everything on tape, but if I had had a school like they have today, the universities — so for that and learning, as long as it doesn't interfere with your personal delivery and your spirit. The thing that I find that happens in a lot of the schools is it's almost like mass production. I mean that's me. And it's like everybody sounding alike and there's no creativity to the point where I'd like to see it. Don't be afraid to take a chance. Say you fall on your face. I do it all the time. What are you going to do, stay where it's safe or go somewhere because you feel it and you hear it. These kids learn all these exercises, and I'm particularly talking about horn players, they learn all these exercises and there's not enough places where they can go out and jam, like they used to do when I was growing up, and if you weren't any good you got kicked off the stage — or come back when you learn the tune okay? Come back when you learn it okay? But they did it good naturedly. Now these kids get up and what are they playing? They play these exercises. Because they don't — their ego, whatever, I don't know, whatever it is. But I just find that it's a mass production and it's kind of like a fad. I'm not saying everybody now Monk, not everybody. But sometimes, "Oh I'm taking a jazz course — oh yeah well I'm a jazz singer." I had a kid come up to me to take a lesson just last week, and she goes to the New School, and she comes into my apartment and I say okay blah blah blah. I said, "Why don't you learn this tune, this minor Blues." Because I always like to start them in major and minor. I said, "Why don't you learn this minor Blues." Well here's a good line, I said, "'Mr. P.C.' written by John Coltrane." "Oh who's Mr. P.C.?" I said, "You don't know who Mr. P.C. is?" "No." I said, "Well it's Paul Chambers." "Well who is he?" So then I have to go through that. And, "Oh what does John Coltrane play?"

MR: Ooh, ouch.

SJ: Now I said, "Oh my darling," you know, but she was sweet, I mean really sweet. So I had to go through that whole thing. I said, "You know what? You ought to take a history course, a jazz history course, I think it would help you a little bit." That doesn't mean I

didn't take her, because strangely enough the depth of her lyric singing, she doesn't have any depth there, but when she improvised she never used shoobie-doobies. She had a wonderful way of singing over changes with a very, very light, lovely syllables and ideas. Little sweet ideas. So that surprised me. But I didn't know that before, the thing. And after that I said, "Now you do that quite well," I said, "but you need to go out there and listen to these monsters and know what's going on." But I think that maybe too, I have to say in support of the schools that they're finding their way too. It's new. So I think little by little, hopefully, they're finding their way and they'll have a different approach eventually, or maybe just not being so hard on these kids. I find a lot of the teachers that are teaching don't play out. They don't go out and do sessions. What do they know about it? What do they know about falling on their faces. You know, "Oh what do you play?" "Well I used to play—" whatever. You know? But they don't go out and do it. So how can you teach the performance you see? What I teach is my own way, which is performance. A lot of it has to do with performance, getting it together, getting music together, getting lead sheets together, knowing how to count time, knowing what a chorus is, knowing how to get in and out and learning the melodies of the tunes, learning the roots, learning how to sing on changes, learning how to sing over the changes. You know? When they're ready. But even in singing lyrics you know [clock] sings. See? But it stopped, it didn't go twelve, didn't go one.

MR: We're in the half hour.

SJ: We're up to the half, the bridge.

MR: Right. Pretty soon we'll be on the out chorus.

SJ: There you go.

MR: If I see you go like this I know that we've got to go out.

SJ: No, if anybody goes out, you're going out because I'll sit here all day and talk about this because I love this music. Anything I can do to preserve it and keep it alive is what I'm here for. This is my calling, whether I'm talking to you and Tim, whether I'm teaching it, whether I'm singing it or whether I'm just listening to it. It's my calling.

MR: The years you spent with a day job, did that make the gigs and recordings you were able to do more precious?

SJ: Yeah. I think so, for me I would say yes. I never thought of myself as a part time singer because I didn't do it full time. I worked in an office for two reasons. I had a daughter to support, I didn't want her raised the way I was raised as a young kid which was in a very, very poverty stricken household. So I kept that day job. They knew that I loved the music and so I could take leaves of absences if I got gigs, or always my vacation time was to do music. I'd save my vacation time and take it in days. The reason that I didn't consider myself a part time musician, because I wasn't thinking in terms of part time money. Pay.

I was not depending on this music to support me. I was depending on this music, I mean financially, I was depending on this music to support me emotionally and keep me alive, which it did. I had a spiritual awakening when I was quite young and which said to me I'll support this music until it can support me and maybe it will never support me financially. But I will support it because I believe in it. And so in so doing and with that attitude I never had a better attitude about working, I never was cynical, I never allowed myself to get too down. There were periods that I went through with my drinking and some of my drugging where I know that was a result of not doing music as much as I wanted to, or possibly even all the way back to other stuff. But the point is that I pulled myself out of it, which was another spiritual awakening, which was, listen, if you don't take care of yourself, this gift I gave you I'm going to take it back and give it to somebody else. And it's not like a voice, not a man's voice, not a woman's voice, just a voice you know? So I've had several spiritual awakenings in my life about the music, and dedicating my life to it. And I know that as long as I worked in the office I could keep the music pure. If I had to go out and make a living with music, that would mean that I would have to do all different kinds of music, because nobody fools us in jazz. We've been out here a long time. You don't make a living in jazz unless you're a great big star and you've got a great big agent, whatever. And then, you know, when I was coming up it wasn't so. I mean not as much. Especially if you're very unique and an original or whatever or you don't have whatever it is you're supposed to have. But the thing was is I never let that get me down. What happened to me is I got fired from my 21 year job at an advertising agency, where I used to even do their commercials. When they wanted a jazz rendition of something they'd say call Sheila. I'd go upstairs and [sings] Softique, the stuff you take a bath in. So I'm singing about Softique to "Body and Soul."

MR: Oh, right.

SJ: And then I did one for Whirlpool refrigerators [sings] The party's over/it's time to call it a day. And it was all about this guy who didn't have an icemaker, for Whirlpool, and the party wouldn't have to be over my friend if you had a Whirlpool icemaker. That kind of stuff. But they wanted that kind of a sound. They wanted a jazz sound. So that would keep me going, you know, because I loved the music. And when I got fired — not even fired I got laid off, or I could choose between staying and working like floating around as they called it, in different places, or leave with a year's severance pay. Because they were merging with another advertising agency. And I said gee, you know what? I said well if have a part time, can I come back after a year and do the floating around? Because I was scared. I'm not going to lie, I was scared. I was afraid to go out there, and I was 58 years old. So I wasn't that too far from Social Security but I know that don't pay anything. So they said of course you can come back. But when she told me that I started to cry. I was

like so — how do they do this to me you know, after I worked here all these 21 years and oh my God and feeling sorry for myself and the whole trip. You know what? I had prayed that I would be able to start singing more. And be careful what you pray for, you might get it. And you know what? I never looked back. I have never looked back. I collected that money for one year, that salary, and I've been working ever since. And I'm doing more work now than I've ever done. Everybody says, "Aren't you going to retire?" I say, "Retire from what?" Retire? That's like telling me to go and dig a grave and jump in it. I'll retire when I go under.

MR: Yeah. Now you're doing what you were meant to do.

SJ: Of course. I'm doing everything I want to do in my life today, it's teaching, it's talking to people like you and going out and doing concerts. I'm constantly working. You know I never though I'd have to turn down gigs, how about that?

MR: Wow. All right. You know early on we had mentioned your Blue Note album, 1962, and Nat Hentoff had said at the time, "Sheila has always had the ultimate confidence, a refusal to compromise." That was way back in '62 he said that.

SJ: Yeah.

MR: And that you don't — you've never felt right about trying to do music that you didn't feel right about.

SJ: Yeah that's harder than working in an office. That's the reason. Because if you want a top 40 type singer, I'm not good. I don't say that's terrible music, it's just not the music I do. So go get somebody who's very good at doing top 40 music. And no — I mean I could have, many years ago, been asked to do certain things and I couldn't do it. I'd hear the music and I'd say I can't get a feeling for it. Why should I do something that I don't feel good about? No. I won't do that and I don't have to do it. Now I don't have to do it at all, because I'm on the way out. I'm not on the way in, I'm on the way out. I don't know where I'm going to go when I leave here. Hopefully it'll still be the music.

MR: I actually have a piece off that album.

SJ: "Portrait?"

MR: Yeah. And I thought I would just—

SJ: I was very sick when I did that album.

MR: Really?

SJ: Yes. I had an operation when I did that album.

[audio interlude]

SJ: This one? I have a whole new thing on this, with the bass. I do a whole thing on this with all dance tunes, dedicated to Fred Astaire. Bass and voice. Yeah. It's never been recorded yet. But I will record it one day.

MR: I hope so.

SJ: Yeah. With Cameron. We'll do it. We just did it last week in Europe, a couple of weeks ago.

MR: Do you like to listen to your own recordings?

SJ: Hate it. Hate it. I hate it. I was sitting upstairs when this is how I don't know my own — I only know it after I record it, go through the mixing, go through the listening to it back and then the final product I listen to it once or twice and then I never listen to it again unless it's playing somewhere if I'm going to somebody's house for a party or something and they have it on, I'll say do you mind not playing that?

MR: Really.

SJ: But just recently I did listen to Blue Note, the Blue Note recording. Because everybody was telling me, giving me really beautiful compliments on it, and I thought gee, what's the big deal? I don't — how come I don't hear it? I don't hear that. That doesn't sound good to me. I mean I remember how I felt when I did it, but what happens is I start listening to it and I say, as most creative musicians, oh that could have gone here, and this could have gone there. You know I can't just sit and enjoy it. Somebody else I can but we hear ourselves differently. But anyway I was upstairs while you all were getting ready to do this. And I heard this intro, and I thought oh my God that's so beautiful. It was Kenny Barron. On "The Water is Wide."

MR: It's this.

SJ: And I thought oh my God isn't that beautiful, that introduction.

MR: It's a beautiful recording.

SJ: Oh yeah that's "Lost and Found." Isn't it?

MR: This is "The Water is Wide."

SJ: Yeah but the name of the CD is "Lost and Found."

MR: Um — "From the Heart."

SJ: Oh you don't have the original.

MR: It's a compilation.

SJ: Oh yeah.

MR: I'm curious, do you think you could have sung this song to your satisfaction in 1962?

SJ: Yeah.

MR: Yeah? That's a nice change here.

SJ: Oh yeah. What I did was I modulated. I made the head arrangement modulating it. Yeah. I love Kenny Barron, he's just so wonderful. We worked — I have a few albums with him. I have one in Japan that I did. But I've been working more with Steve now again after — we had our group together for a while and then that sort of didn't make it and then so we recorded with different people. And then I went back to Ken again. I think

he's so underrated. He's such a beautiful player. But no, I like that song. Fred Hirsch gave me that song.

MR: Really?

SJ: Fred Hirsch gave me that song.

MR: That's an old, old song.

SJ: It's an old Scottish folk song. It's an old, I think it's Scottish. It's either Scottish or British. I think it's from Scotland though. I think so. And he played that for me. He said, "I have a song that I think you could really sing." And he played it and he gave me a tape of him singing it and playing it and I started to cry. I said oh my God this is so beautiful. Actually on the back of the original that that's on, "Lost and Found" I thanked him for giving me that.

MR: Do you do your own booking and business?

SJ: Yeah.

MR: Good for you.

SJ: I do because I never found anybody out there that wanted to — and I'm very easy to get along with. I don't think I'm a quote saleable unquote commodity. I think that it's special people will book me. I get a lot of work in Europe. But you know who books me? The musicians. Bless their hearts. If it wasn't for the jazz musicians I would never work. They're the ones who have always gotten me the gigs. Always. Teaching, everything. So I'm very, very grateful. Because usually you'd say oh well, instrumentalists can't stand singers. You know? They've just been the nicest to me.

MR: That's great.

SJ: But I had to earn it.

MR: Do you ever find it irksome when you hear the comment, "Now here's a singer who's a real musician?"

SJ: What does that mean? You know? I mean it doesn't irk me but I just say now what does that mean, you know, what does that mean. Here's a horn player who's a real horn player? I mean here's a piano player who's a real — they wouldn't say that. But a singer who's a real musician. Here's a piano player who's a real musician. Of course he's a real musician. I guess what they're trying to say is somebody who really knows the music, because I can talk to anybody on the level of any instrumentalist and know what I'm talking about, whereas most singers only know other singers. That's another reason, getting back to that learning from singers, it has to do with really digging the music. I say "do you want to learn this music? Do you want to really do this music? Then you've got to wake up with it in the morning, have it with you. Ask me how do I feel. Remember Miles? That was his intro to "If I Were a Bell."

MR: So you do know the music.

SJ: Of course. Well I told you about the Monk tune, so that's proof. But actually I think that if singers really got into the music, where they did, woke up with it in the morning, had it in their life all day in their ear all day, and went to bed with it at night. That's what I did. I'm addicted to this music. And when I was younger, first learning it, oh my God. It's such a joy it's such a gift.

MR: It's amazing to me that from your childhood in Pennsylvania that somehow you found a path to this music.

SJ: Yeah.

MR: Was there music in your grandparents' house?

SJ: Well you know as a little kid I used to do a lot of improvising because my grandmother was a beautiful singer and she played the piano. And my great grandfather, who was from the Native American, was a wonderful painter but they said he had a wonderful singing voice. And of course my grandfather when he got drunk, which was most of the time, loved to sing. But he wasn't that good. But my grandmother was very good. But what I did as a kid, I used to sing just like — kind of like improvising like on Native American kind of things. Which I'm bringing more into my music now, which is not anything written down or special, but it always gets an audience. They always say wow, where did that come from? That sounded very American Indian. I say well it is I guess, it comes from in here, in my soul. So I take off on that kind of thing. And when I was little I used to have to pass a graveyard so I was always like improvising and singing to the hills. Plus I was a Fred Astaire freak. So I'd walk two miles, scrub a woman's floor, walk two miles from the money she gave me and go see Fred Astaire in South Fork, Pennsylvania, just so I could try to learn those songs. [sings] Heaven/I'm in heaven. Right? [scats]. Poor Tim. What's she doing?

MR: Wow. That was a nice little bridge there between those two things.

SJ: Yeah it's all music, it's all music, Monk.

MR: I wondered if I played a Blues on the piano if you would improvise something?

SJ: Sure. Absolutely. Can you play it in G? I know you can. So do me a Blues in G. As it is in G. Here's the top. One-two-three-four—

[audio interlude]

MR: Thank you so much.

SJ: You're very welcome. Did ya have a good time? I did. Oh God, all right. Well you must have something on there. You know you don't have to use it all.

MR: Right. Thank you.

SJ: Thanks for coming. Do you want a sandwich or some coffee or tea before you go? No but I have a little turkey.

MR: We're fine.